

9.8 The Holocaust

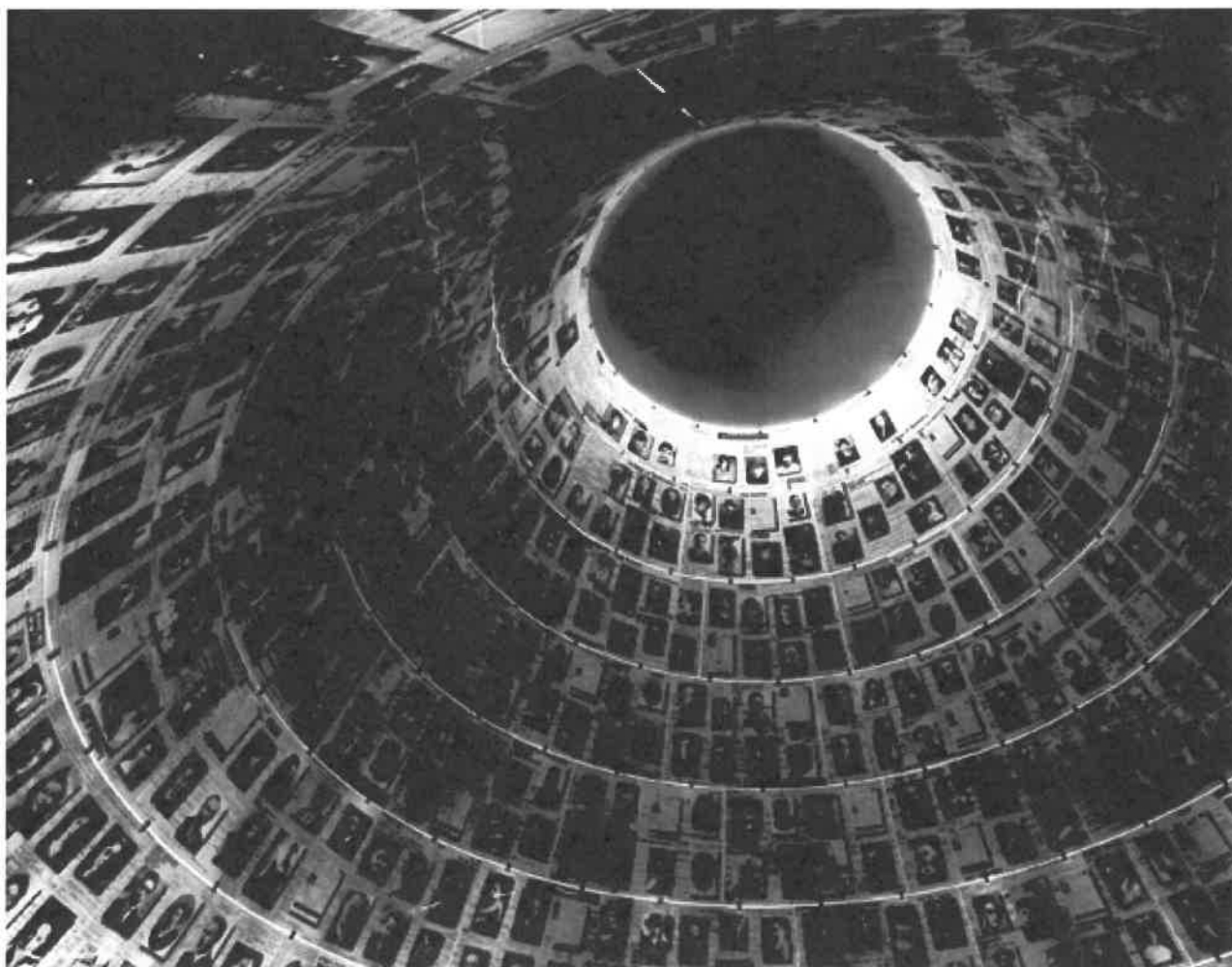
In 1933, it is estimated that the Jewish population of Europe stood at around 11 million. By the end of the war in 1945, it is estimated that more than six million Jews had died at the hands of the Nazis. To put this into perspective, more than half of all European Jews were killed. This systematic, government-endorsed persecution and murder of Jews took place throughout the Nazi-occupied territories under the command of Adolf Hitler. It is among the most brutal and destructive policies of the 20th century, and is referred to as the Holocaust. Hundreds of thousands of German military and civilian personnel were involved in the mass murder. Millions more collaborated or accepted these

events without protest. The word 'Holocaust' is of Greek origin and means 'sacrificed by fire' or 'burnt'. Out of respect for the dead, Jewish communities today use the Hebrew word *Shoah* instead, meaning 'catastrophe'.

Beginnings of the Holocaust

The origins of the Holocaust can be traced back further than Hitler's lifetime. Antisemitism has its origins in the ancient world, and was rife throughout Europe in the Middle Ages.

In the 1880s, the eugenics movement became popular. Eugenics, a practice that aimed to 'improve'



Source 1 The conical-shaped Hall of Names in the Holocaust History Museum in the Yad Vashem Holocaust complex in Israel – the Hall of Names shows around 600 portraits of Jewish Holocaust victims.



Source 2 Nazi storm troopers (also known as brownshirts) outside a Jewish business, directing people to shop elsewhere, 1933

the human gene pool by controlling the types of people giving birth to children, was taught as a subject at many universities. For a time, eugenics was supported by people like Winston Churchill, and was government policy in countries such as the United States. By the 1930s the popularity of the eugenics movement was declining, but the Nazi Party's policies were heavily influenced by its ideas.

Hitler outlined the development of his antisemitism and even some of his proposed policies towards Jews in his book *Mein Kampf*. Many of these beliefs were borrowed from the eugenics movement. He declared that 'the personification of the devil as the symbol of all evil assumes the living shape of the Jew'. *Mein Kampf* also outlined Hitler's hatred of communism, and his belief that Germany would have to expand east to provide Lebensraum ('living space') for ethnic Germans. The seeds of Hitler's cruel and murderous policies were present in his ideology at least a decade before he became Chancellor of Germany in 1933.

Within months of coming to power, Hitler also introduced a law that allowed the compulsory sterilisation of people with mental or physical disabilities. In other words, anyone who was disabled (a broad definition of 'disabled' was used, ranging from schizophrenia, to deafness, to alcoholism) could be legally forced to have an operation to ensure they could not have children. More than 400 000 people were sterilised and around 5000 died as a result of these operations. Another 70 000 were killed under a related euthanasia program.

Antisemitism and eugenics eventually combined in Germany's racial policies. As well as violence against Jews and boycotts of Jewish businesses (see Source 2), the government refused to grant German citizenship to Jews and sought to remove all Jews from the government, the legal professions and universities. Laws limited the number of Jewish students allowed in public schools, banned Jews from many public places, expelled Jewish officers from the army, and transferred ownership of many Jewish businesses to non-Jewish Germans.

As Hitler's policies began to take hold, many Jews (and Germans) refused to believe the reality of what was taking place around them. Some, including the famous scientist Albert Einstein, left Germany. Others believed that they would be protected because they were German citizens. By the time the reality dawned, they had been stripped of their citizenship and, often, the avenues of escape had been closed to them.

In 1938 there was a wave of violence directed against Jewish synagogues, businesses and houses across Germany. It was known as *Kristallnacht* or the 'Night of Broken Glass'. While there is no doubt that this was organised by the Nazis, Hitler claimed that it was a spontaneous attack by German people, and that it showed the depth of anti-Jewish feeling. The Nazi regime was widely criticised in the international press as a result of *Kristallnacht*.



Source 3 A cloth Star of David badge that Jews were required to wear in public – the word 'Jude' means 'Jew' in German

Spread of antisemitism and the formation of ghettos

Soon after the invasion of Poland in 1939, **ghettos** were set up in Nazi-occupied territories, such as Poland, Hungary and the Soviet Union. Ghettos were small areas of larger cities that were used to isolate Jews from the rest of the population. They were bricked off or encircled with barbed wire to stop people from escaping. Over the course of the war, many Jewish people were rounded up and forced to leave their homes



Source 4 A Jewish youth selling Star of David armbands in Warsaw

and move into ghettos. One of the largest ghettos was in Warsaw, Nazi-occupied Poland (see Source 5). Conditions inside the ghetto were extremely brutal. It was very crowded and there was often no running water, or toilet facilities. Jews were often not allowed to leave the ghetto and had to depend on the few rations provided by the Nazis. One survivor described the Warsaw ghetto as 'a prison without a roof'. Approximately 800 000 Jews died in the ghettos from malnutrition, disease and forced labour. Others were murdered outright by shooting.

Although the principal victims of the Holocaust were European Jews, Nazi policies also targeted other segments of society, such as Sinti and Romani peoples (often referred to as Gypsies) as well as homosexuals and people with physical or intellectual disabilities. Between 200 000 and 500 000 Sinti and Romani peoples alone were killed by the Nazis. These criminal actions were later labelled **genocide** – the deliberate attempt to wipe out a religious, racial or ethnic group. Nazi occupation policies, particularly in Eastern and Central Europe, were also brutal. In Poland and the Soviet Union, for instance, they resulted in the deaths of millions of civilians.

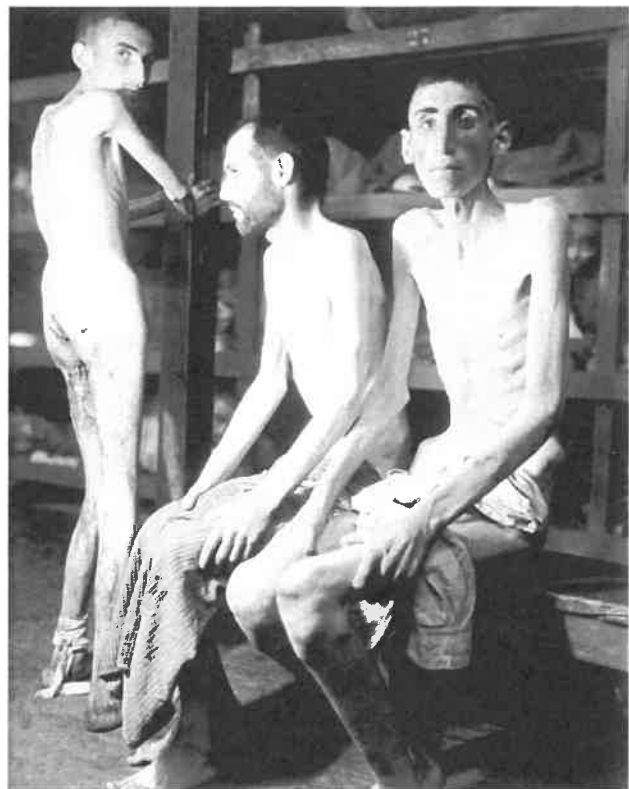


Source 5 The clearing of Jews from the Warsaw ghetto in Nazi-occupied Poland in 1943. Towards the end of the war, German troops cleared ghettos and transported those living in them to concentration camps either to work or to be killed.

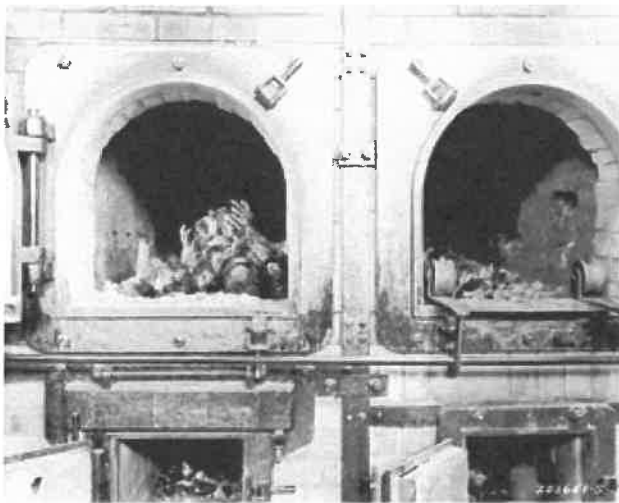
Concentration camps

In addition to the formation of ghettos in large cities to confine Jews and other 'undesirables', the Nazi government used existing concentration camps in Germany and built many new camps throughout the occupied territories, mostly in Poland. The exact number of concentration camps is not known; however, it is generally accepted that there were between 2000 and 8000 camps.

The camps varied in character. Some were forced labour camps where inmates were compelled to do hard physical labour such as mining and road building under harsh conditions (see Source 6). Others were prisoner of war camps where Allied soldiers were held and often tortured in order to reveal secret information. Still others functioned as extermination camps designed for the sole purpose of murdering. Many camps, however, served a combination of these functions. The best known and largest of these camps was Auschwitz-Birkenau, where inmates considered unsuitable for forced labour were gassed and their bodies burnt in crematoria (giant ovens – see Source 7). More than one million Jews alone were murdered at Auschwitz.



Source 6 Russian, Polish and Dutch slave labourers interned at the Buchenwald concentration camp had an average weight of 75 kilograms each before entering camp. Eleven months later, when this photograph was taken, their average weight had dropped to 31 kilograms.



Source 7 Crematoria where the remains of people killed at Buchenwald concentration camp were cremated

Mass shootings

With the invasion of the Soviet Union in June 1941, Nazi policy towards the Jews began to move into its most extreme phase. Between the start of the invasion and early 1943, roughly 1.6 million eastern European Jews were executed in mass killing campaigns that were conducted by members of the *Einsatzgruppen* (mobile

killing squads). Local collaborators, the SS (Hitler's elite forces) and some members of the *Wehrmacht* (German armed forces) also participated in this extermination. The process generally involved rounding up the members of a local Jewish community and executing them in an area close to their homes. On 29–30 September 1941 at Babi Yar, near the city of Kiev, 33 771 Jews were executed. This phase of the Holocaust was the most public, and rumours of executions began to spread in the occupied areas and in Germany itself.

The 'Final Solution'

In January 1942, at a meeting in the city of Wannsee near Berlin, leading Nazi officials identified a process to achieve a 'final solution to the Jewish question'. The aim was to eliminate the estimated 11 million European Jews. This 'Final Solution' combined forced deportation and transportation of Jews to labour camps before extermination.

Historians generally agree that around 3 million Jews were killed in concentration and extermination camps, while another 3 million died in other violent or oppressive circumstances outside the camps. All 6 million deaths were a result of Nazi extermination policies. Many other non-Jewish inmates died of maltreatment, disease and starvation.



Source 8 Polish prisoners dig graves for their fellow prisoners after a mass execution by the Nazis, 1941.

The Holocaust's legacy

More than 6 million of Europe's 11 million Jews were killed in a deliberate campaign of extermination during the Holocaust. Some survivors endured slave labour in the various camps. Many others hid or were protected by sympathetic non-Jews. There were also those who took up arms against the Nazis, such as the Jewish Combat Organisation whose members led uprisings in some of the major ghettos.

After the war, many European Jews migrated to other countries, including Australia, where they have established vibrant new communities. After enduring the horrors of the Holocaust, many Jews wished to join their fellow Jews who were already living in their ancient homeland. So, in November 1947, the United Nations endorsed the establishment of an independent Jewish state in what became known as Israel (see Topic 9.14). Israel declared its independence in May 1948.

The horrors of the mass murders and other atrocities committed by the Nazis shocked people all around the world. After World War II, the nations of the world were determined to prevent such grave crimes from ever happening again or, at least, ensuring that people committing such crimes would not go unpunished. The facts and lessons of these events are commemorated in Holocaust museums that have been established in many countries, while memoirs and films communicate the Jewish experience of the *Shoah* to the world. New international treaties on human rights, the humane treatment of civilians in times of war, sanctuary for refugees and the elimination of racial discrimination have come into effect since the events of the Holocaust. These treaties, such as the Declaration of Human Rights, recognise the inherent dignity and equal and inalienable rights of all members of the human race as the foundation of freedom, justice and peace in the world.



Source 9 These are the tracks along which trains took people to their death at the Auschwitz-Birkenau concentration camp in Oswiecim, Nazi-occupied Poland.

Check your learning 9.8

Remember and understand

- 1 What does the word 'Holocaust' mean? What term do Jewish communities use to refer to the Holocaust?
- 2 What was the eugenics movement? How popular was it?
- 3 What were some of the laws implemented during Nazi Germany to persecute Jews?
- 4 Apart from Jews, who else were persecuted by the Nazis?
- 5 Explain the difference between concentration camps and extermination camps.
- 6 What was the 'Final Solution' and how was it carried out?
- 7 Why do some sources say that there were six million victims of the Holocaust, and some say 11 million?
- 8 What are some of the ways in which people have ensured that the events of the Holocaust will not be forgotten?

Apply and analyse

- 9 Hitler outlined his antisemitic attitudes in his book *Mein Kampf*, and introduced antisemitic policies after coming to power in 1933. Why do you think that so few Jews fled Germany before it was too late?

Evaluate and create

- 10 Some Holocaust survivors who spent time in the Auschwitz-Birkenau camp have said that the people who were sent to the gas chambers were the 'lucky ones'. Conduct some research into the conditions faced by Auschwitz prisoners. Why do you think survivors have made these types of statements?

9.9 The atomic bombings

In addition to the horrific events of the Holocaust, the dropping of the atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, which effectively ended the war, is remembered as one of most significant events of World War II.

The development of more sophisticated technology in World War II culminated in the invention of the atomic bomb. In spite of the horrific bombing raids experienced in Europe during the war, the use of nuclear weapons remains a symbol of the terrifying force and destructive effects of war. The use of the two bombs that successfully ended the war also marked the beginning of the Cold War and the ever-present threat of nuclear destruction.

The Potsdam Declaration

Following the end of the war in Europe, the Allies turned their attention to the war in the Pacific – with the goal of forcing Japan to surrender. At the Potsdam Conference in July 1945, the Allied leaders issued the Potsdam Declaration to Japan. This was an ultimatum, threatening that if Japan did not unconditionally surrender it would face ‘prompt and utter destruction’.

The Manhattan Project

The Manhattan Project was the name given to the research program that developed the first atomic bomb. It had its origins in a letter from two of the world's leading physicists, Leo Szilard and Albert Einstein, that was sent to President Franklin D. Roosevelt in 1939. The letter outlined their fears that Nazi Germany was beginning research into atomic bombs, and recommended that the USA should begin its own nuclear program. Roosevelt accepted their proposal, and began funding secret research into atomic energy. In 1942, the research program was placed under the command of the American military, and became the Manhattan Project.

Even before the USA entered World War II, it was dedicating huge resources to the Manhattan Project. By 1944, approximately 129 000 people were working on the Manhattan Project, including scientists, construction workers and military personnel. Included was a physicist



Source 1 Robert Oppenheimer and General Leslie Groves examine the wreckage of the tower and shack that held the first nuclear weapon, 11 September 1945.

named Robert Oppenheimer (see Source 1) who became known as the ‘father of the atomic bomb’ for his role in the project.

After three years of using their research to develop a weapon, members of the Manhattan Project tested the first atomic bomb on 16 July 1945, in New Mexico. This test was code-named ‘Trinity’.

The Trinity test was extremely successful. At the time it was the largest human-made explosion in history. The shock wave made by the explosion was felt up to 160 kilometres away. The test observers immediately contacted President Harry Truman, who was at the Potsdam Conference, and told him that they had been successful. The following month, two other atomic bombs developed by the Manhattan Project were dropped on Hiroshima (on 6 August 1945) and Nagasaki (on 9 August 1945), Japan, in what history would record as the last major acts of World War II.

The Japan campaign

In mid-1945, Japan was losing the war in the Pacific. The USA had recaptured the Mariana Islands and the Philippines, and Japan was running out of resources.

The Japan campaign began with a series of minor air raids. These raids soon developed into a major strategic firebombing campaign in late 1944, which involved dropping large numbers of small bombs designed to start fires. The change to firebombing tactics resulted in devastating attacks on 67 Japanese cities, killing as many as 500 000 people. Despite the damage and the huge civilian death toll, the Japanese military refused to surrender.

The USA therefore continued to push towards the Japanese Home Islands (the islands that the Allies had



Source 2 US marines watch a phosphorous shell attack on the Japanese in the Battle of Okinawa.

decided would be the extent of Japan's territory after the war). Two major land battles, at Iwo Jima and Okinawa, revealed how fierce Japan's defence of the Home Islands would be. Both islands were heavily fortified and fiercely defended. Around 6800 American troops and approximately 21 000 Japanese soldiers were killed at Iwo Jima. The Battle of Okinawa (see Source 2) was the bloodiest in the Pacific, with 50 000 Americans wounded, and 12 000 killed. Approximately 95 000 Japanese soldiers were killed, including many who committed suicide rather than surrender. It is unknown how many civilians were killed in the American invasion of Okinawa, but estimates vary from 42 000 to 150 000.

Despite the immense loss of life on both sides at Iwo Jima and Okinawa, the American commanders in the Pacific continued preparations for Operation Downfall, the plan to invade Japan. The Soviet Union also prepared to enter the war in the Pacific, planning to declare war on Japan and invade the Japanese-occupied region of Manchuria on 9 August. However, these commanders were not aware of the Manhattan Project. Japan's rejection of the Potsdam Declaration in July 1945 caused President Truman to authorise the atomic bombings of Japanese cities, hoping that it would force Japan to surrender and save millions of lives that might be lost in Operation Downfall.

The bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki

On 6 August 1945, an atomic bomb nicknamed 'Little Boy' was dropped on the city of Hiroshima (see Source 3). Hiroshima was chosen because it was a large, urban, industrial city that also served as a military storage area and an assembly point for troops. No one knew how



Source 3 'Little Boy' – the atomic bomb that destroyed almost 70 per cent of Hiroshima in August 1945

much damage the bomb would do, so Hiroshima was one of the few major cities not targeted by the American firebombing campaign. In that way the damage caused by the bomb could be more easily observed.

The bombing occurred at 8.15 on a Monday morning in Hiroshima. The city's residents had been given no warning of the atomic bombing. The bomb's immediate impact was incredible. Approximately 80 000 people, or 30 per cent of Hiroshima's population, were killed, and another 70 000 were injured. Roughly 69 per cent of the city's buildings were completely destroyed. The long-term effects of the bombing were even worse. People suffered from burns, radiation, cancer and many other side effects. The exact figures are disputed, but the total number of deaths caused by the bomb by the end of 1945 was between 90 000 and 160 000. By 1950, around 200 000 people had died because of side effects from the bomb.

After the bombing of Hiroshima, President Truman released a statement saying that a new weapon had been used, and that 'if they [the Japanese government] do not now accept our terms, they may expect a rain of ruin from the air'. On the same day, the Soviet Union declared war on Japan and invaded the Manchuria region. However, the Japanese government still did not respond to the Potsdam Declaration. On 9 August, a second atomic bomb was dropped on the port city of Nagasaki.

The bomb's impact on Nagasaki was just as devastating as it was on Hiroshima. Between 40 000 and 75 000 people were killed by the immediate effects of the bomb, and a further 74 000 were injured. By the end of 1945, at least 80 000 were dead because of the bomb's long-term effects.

keyconcept: Empathy

The story of Sadako Sasaki

Sadako Sasaki is one of the most famous victims of the atomic bombings in Japan during World War II. She was only two when the atomic bomb was dropped on her home city of Hiroshima. She survived the explosion, but began to develop symptoms nearly a decade after the bombing. In November 1954, Sasaki developed swelling on her neck, and purple spots on her legs. She was diagnosed with leukaemia, and hospitalised in February 1955.

While in hospital, she was visited by a friend who taught her to fold paper to make origami cranes. There is a Japanese tradition that folding 1000 paper cranes brings good luck and grants the person who folds them one wish. Sasaki attempted to fold 1000 cranes, but died in October 1955 before she could complete her task. Her friends and family finished the cranes, and built a memorial to Sasaki, and all the children who were affected by the bombings.

Sasaki's story is just one of tens of thousands of victims of the atomic bombings. Her story puts a human face on the suffering of the victims, and helps to ensure that the victims are not considered simply as statistics.

For more information on the key concept of empathy, refer to page 226 of 'The history toolkit'.



Source 4 Statue of Sadako Sasaki holding a crane in the Peace Memorial Park in Hiroshima

Japan surrenders

Japan was shocked and devastated by the two atomic bombings and the declaration of war by the Soviet Union. Although the Japanese military commanders wanted to continue fighting the war, Emperor Hirohito ordered his government to surrender.

On 14 August the Japanese government notified the Allies that it would accept the terms of the Potsdam Declaration, provided the Emperor retained full sovereignty of Japan (the right to rule independently and free of foreign influence). That night, members of the Japanese military attempted to overthrow the government and remove Emperor Hirohito from power. They were unsuccessful. On 15 August 1945, Hirohito's surrender speech was broadcast on Japanese radio, marking the end of World War II. The formal declaration of surrender was signed on 2 September, and the Allies occupied Japan from that date until 1952.

Debate about the bombings

Immediately after World War II ended, most Americans supported the use of the atomic bombs to force Japan to surrender. Disturbing images of maimed survivors were censored in the USA, and many people were so used to anti-Japanese propaganda that they felt little empathy for the victims of the bombings. Since then, however, there have been fierce debates over whether the atomic bombings were justified or necessary to win the war.

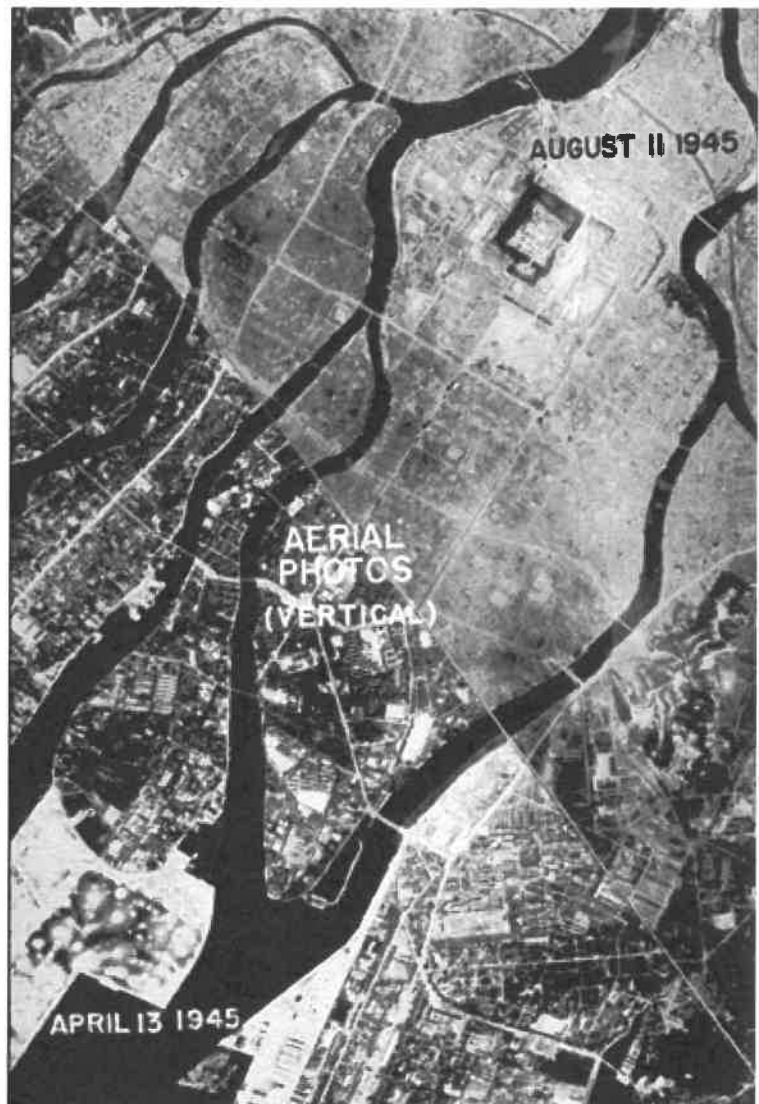
Some argue that the bombings saved millions of lives by preventing the need for an invasion of the Japanese Home Islands. The ferocity with which Japanese soldiers fought at Iwo Jima and Okinawa made this a popular view among American soldiers and their families. Other supporters of the decision to use the atomic bombs say that Japan's 'never surrender' warrior culture meant that, without the bombings, Japan would not have surrendered. Another argument is that the atomic bombings were the inevitable result

of both sides engaging in total war. At the time, many people believed that it would not be practical to spend \$2 billion on the Manhattan Project, and then decide not to use the atomic bombs created to save American lives.

Some critics of the bombings argue that the surprise bombing of civilians with nuclear weapons was fundamentally and morally wrong. Others argue that the bombings constituted war crimes, or crimes against humanity. In a 2003 interview, Robert McNamara, who was the US Secretary of Defence from 1961 to 1968, recalled General Curtis LeMay, who was involved in planning the bombings, telling him that 'if we'd lost the war, we'd all have been prosecuted as war criminals'.



Source 5 General Sir Thomas Blamey, the commander of the Australian army, accepts the surrender of the 2nd Japanese Army on the island of Morotai, in September 1945 (AWM 115645).



Source 6 Hiroshima before (13 April 1945) and after (11 August 1945) the atomic bombing

Check your learning 9.9

Remember and understand

- 1 What were some of the reasons for the choice of Hiroshima as the target for the first atomic bombing?
- 2 Who sent the letter to President Roosevelt that kick-started the Manhattan Project? What were the two main points of the letter?
- 3 What was Operation Downfall? Why was it never fully carried out?

Evaluate and create

- 4 Outline some of the arguments for and against the atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in World War II. Do you believe the bombings were justified?
- 5 Collect a series of images and quotations to create a PowerPoint presentation showing the impact of the atomic bombings of Hiroshima or Nagasaki. You should consider both the short- and long-term effects of the bombings.